PECORINO SARDO PDO



THE BASICS

MAKE:	Hard
SUB MAKE:	Cheeses which acidify in the mould
POST-MAKE:	Wrapped, Rolled or Processed
SUB POST-MAKE:	Artificial (plastic coating, wax coat, matured in vacuum pack)
TYPICAL AGE PROFILE:	Mild: 20-60 days; Mature: two to 12 months
APPROXIMATE WEIGHT(S):	Mild: 2kg; Mature: 3-4kg
GEOGRAPHICAL ORIGIN:	Sardinia, Italy
PROTECTED STATUS:	PDO - must be made in Sardinia with sheep's milk
SPECIES OF MILKING ANIMAL:	Sheep
BREED OF SHEEP:	Breed not specified
RAW/PASTEURISED MILK:	Typically pasteurised or thermised milk
VEGETARIAN/ANIMAL RENNET:	Animal rennet
COMMONLY ENCOUNTERED VARIATIONS:	N/A

THE STORY

Shepherds have wandered the sun-drenched pastures of Sardinia for thousands of years and sheep's milk cheeses are a speciality of the Italian island. The milk would traditionally have been heated over open fires in cauldrons with hot stones placed inside during the cheesemaking process. Not to be confused with Fiore Sardo, Pecorino Sardo is a hard cheese made in two styles: dolce (sweet/mild) and maturo (mature), and is an essential part of the island's rural economy. The curd is set with animal rennet and broken up to the size of hazelnuts for the younger cheese or grains of rice for the mature version, and then heated. The curds are then pressed in the moulds and can be dry-salted or brined. The rind is typically plasticoated or rubbed in olive oil.

THE CHARACTER

The mild cheese has a straw yellow interior, often scattered with small holes, plus a firm but springy texture. The sides of the cheese are often slightly convex. It is mild and sweet. Pecorino Sardo Maturo has straight sides, a more golden hue and a hard, grainy texture. The flavour is more intense and salty.

PERFECT PARTNERS:

Both are good for grating over pasta dishes and are used in the local speciality Culurgiones – pockets of dough stuffed with ricotta, Pecorino Sardo and mint. In Sardinia, they eat the cheese with a juicy red grape called Cannonau (grenache) – key elements of a diet that many believe is responsible for Sardinians' famously long lives.

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